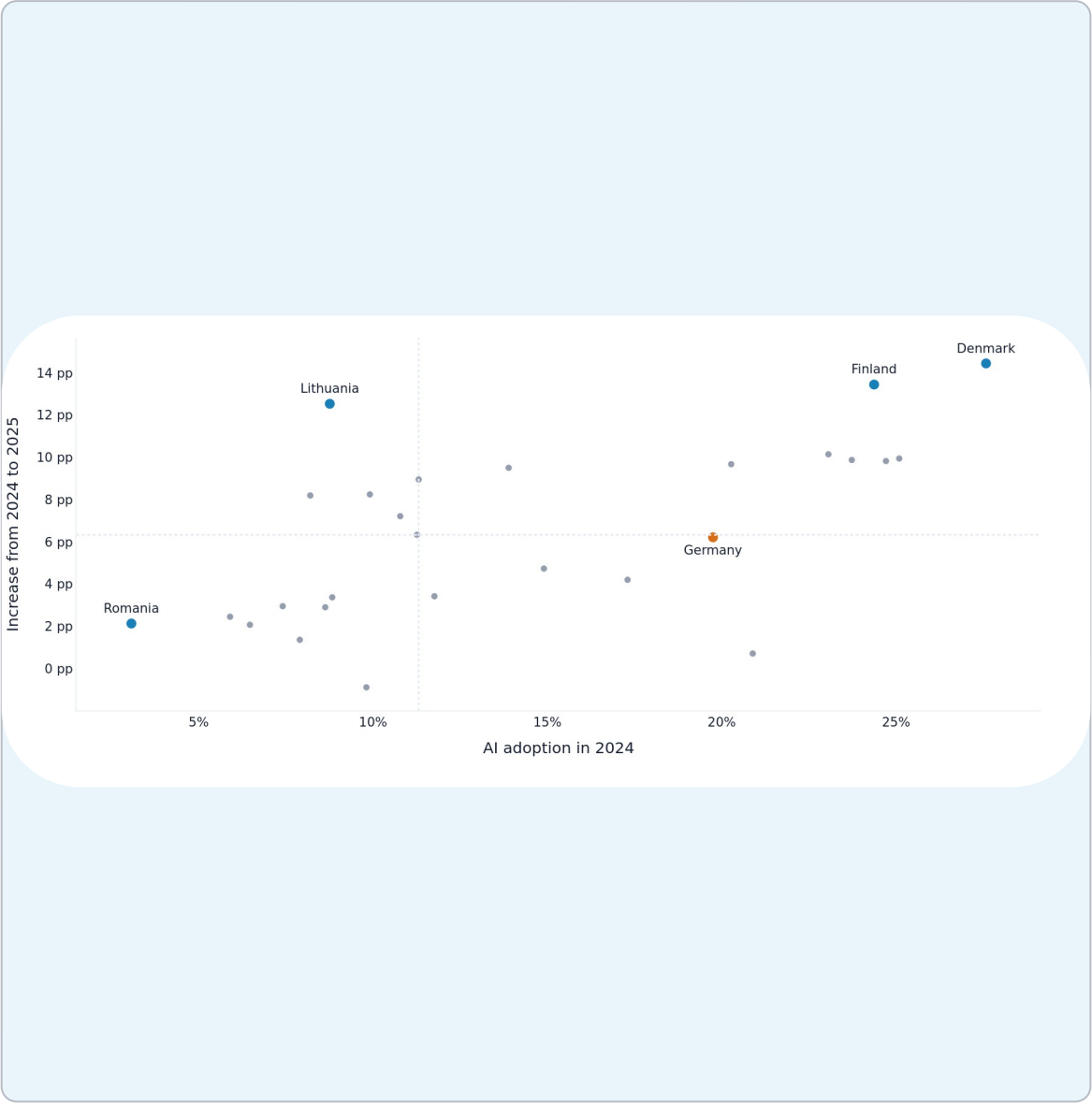


Europe's AI Adoption Gap

Who is pulling ahead, where smaller firms fall behind, and what stops businesses from adopting AI?

Usaid Aamer



The analysis follows one question through four layers

Can rapid AI adoption close Europe's business capability gap?

Official Eurostat survey data
27 EU countries
2023-2025
43,881 curated observations

01

Pace

How fast is adoption growing?

02

Divide

Who is being left behind?

03

Depth

Are firms using one tool or a stack?

04

Blockers

What prevents interested firms from adopting?

The story in three numbers

The central pattern

EU enterprise AI adoption hit 20% in 2025. But national, firm-size, and capability gaps remain wide.

20.0%

EU firms using AI in 2025

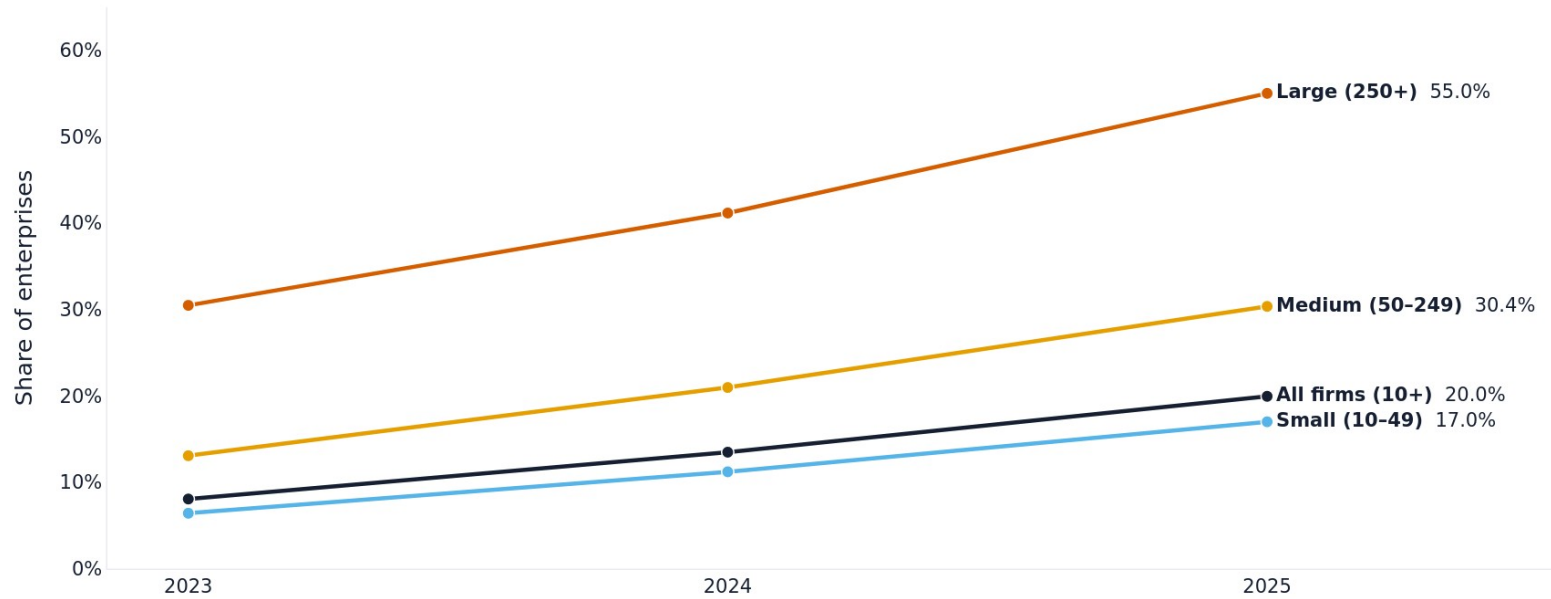
38 pp

Large-small adoption gap

70.3%

Interested non-users citing skills

AI adoption surged, but large firms still lead by 38 points



What the chart means

55.0%

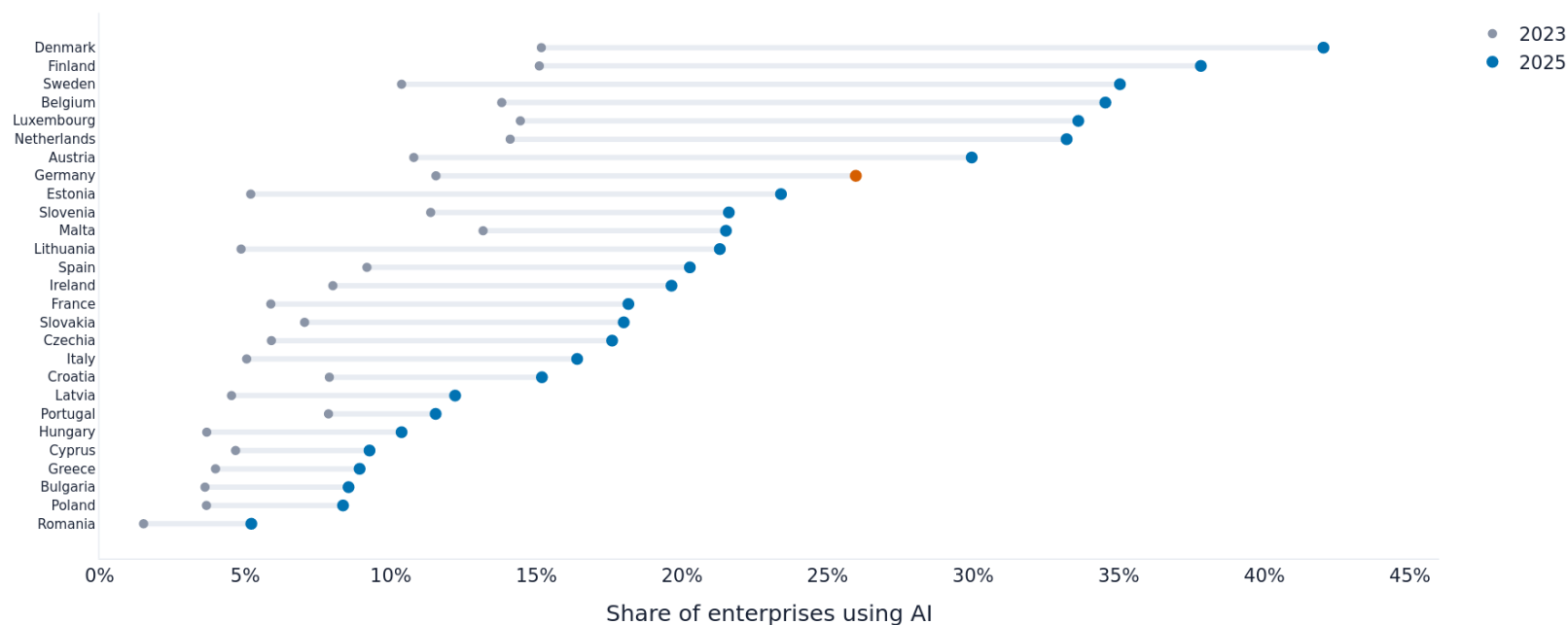
Large firms using AI

17.0%

Small firms using AI

Growth is broad, but it is not equal.

Rapid growth has not closed the 37-point country divide



What the chart means

42.0%

Denmark, 2025

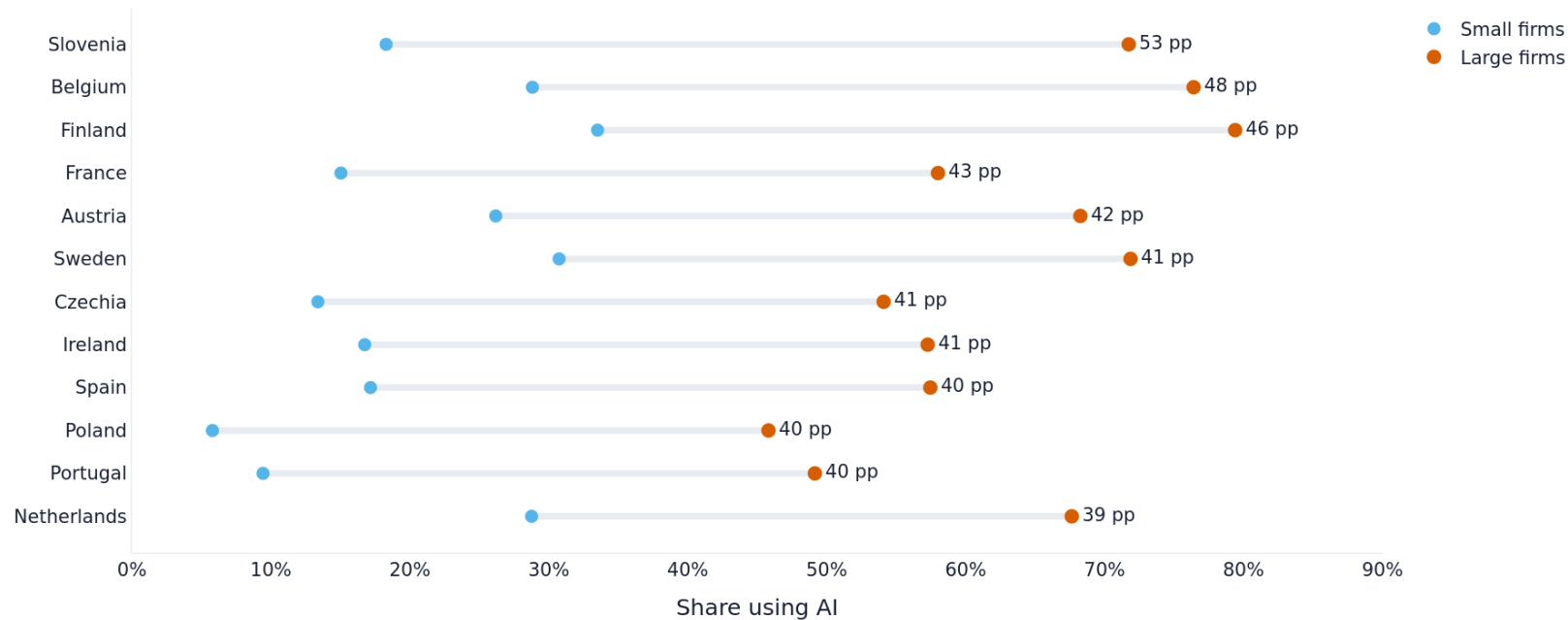
5.2%

Romania, 2025

Several leaders accelerated faster than the laggards.

Firm size is Europe's most consistent AI fault line

What the chart means



53.5 pp

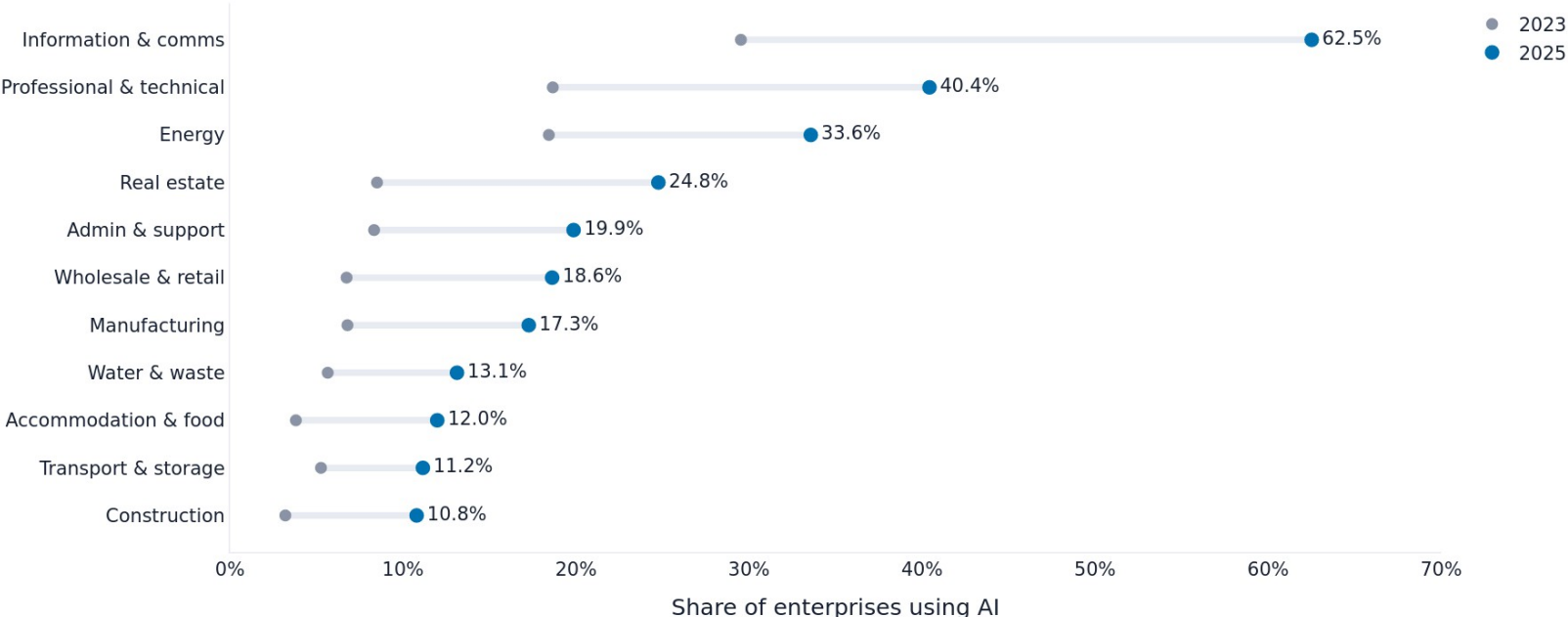
Slovenia's large-small gap

47.6 pp

Belgium's large-small gap

High national adoption does not guarantee equal access.

Information and communication reached 63%; construction stays near 11%



What the chart means

62.5%

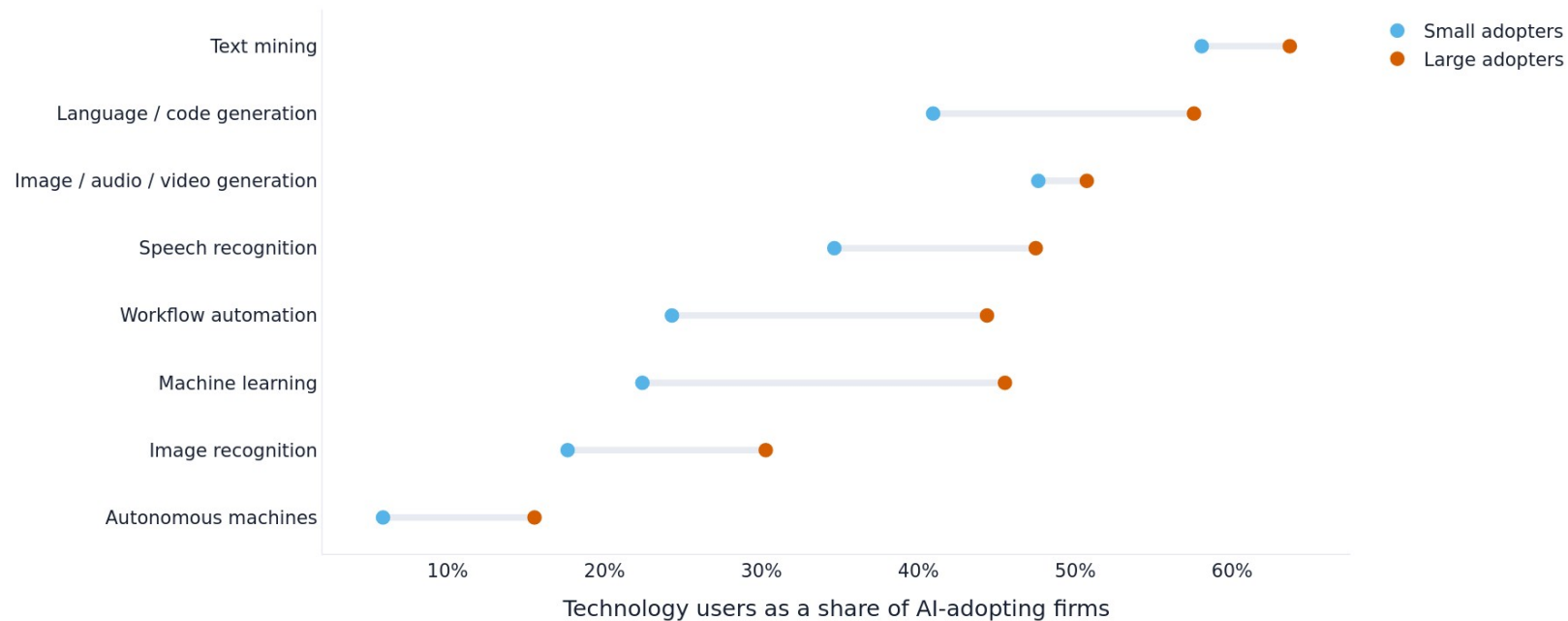
Information and communication

10.8%

Construction

Sector relevance and digital maturity shape the ceiling.

Large adopters build a broader AI technology stack



What the chart means

45.5%

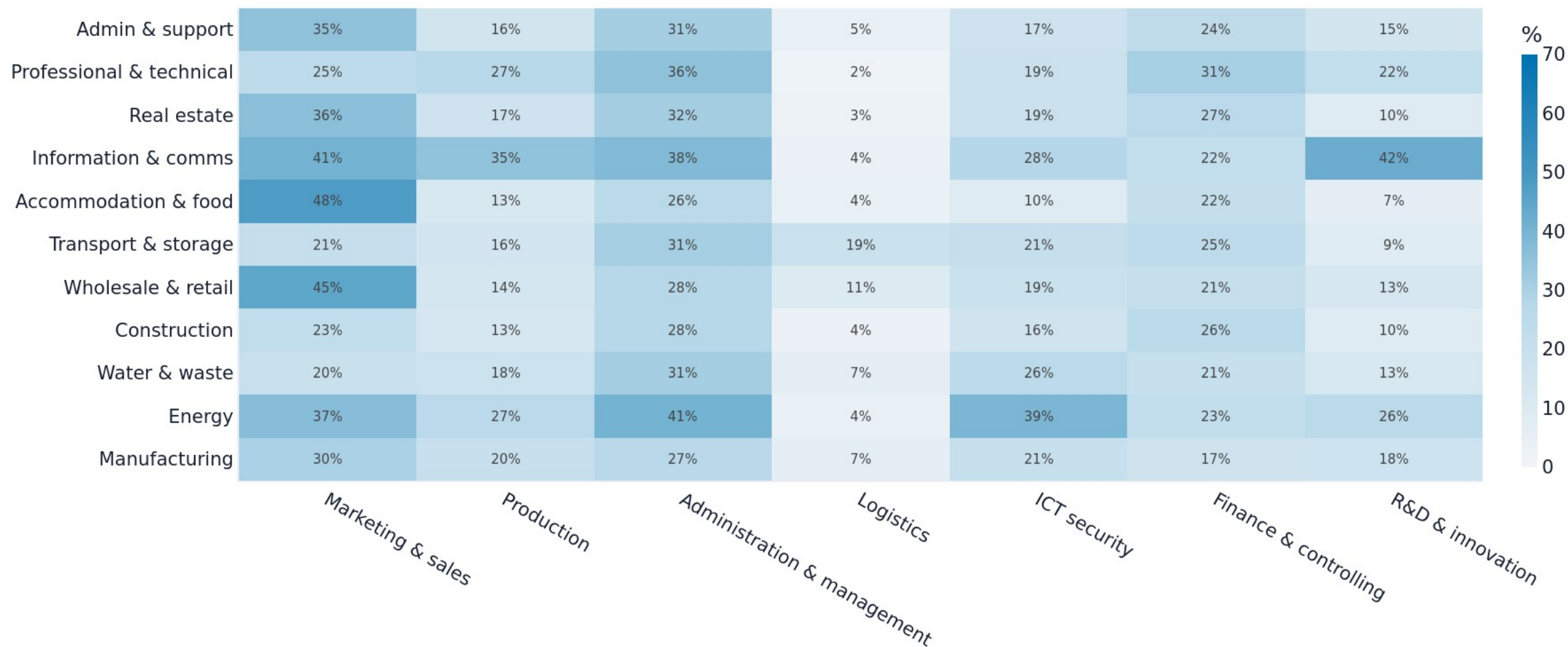
Large adopters using machine learning

22.4%

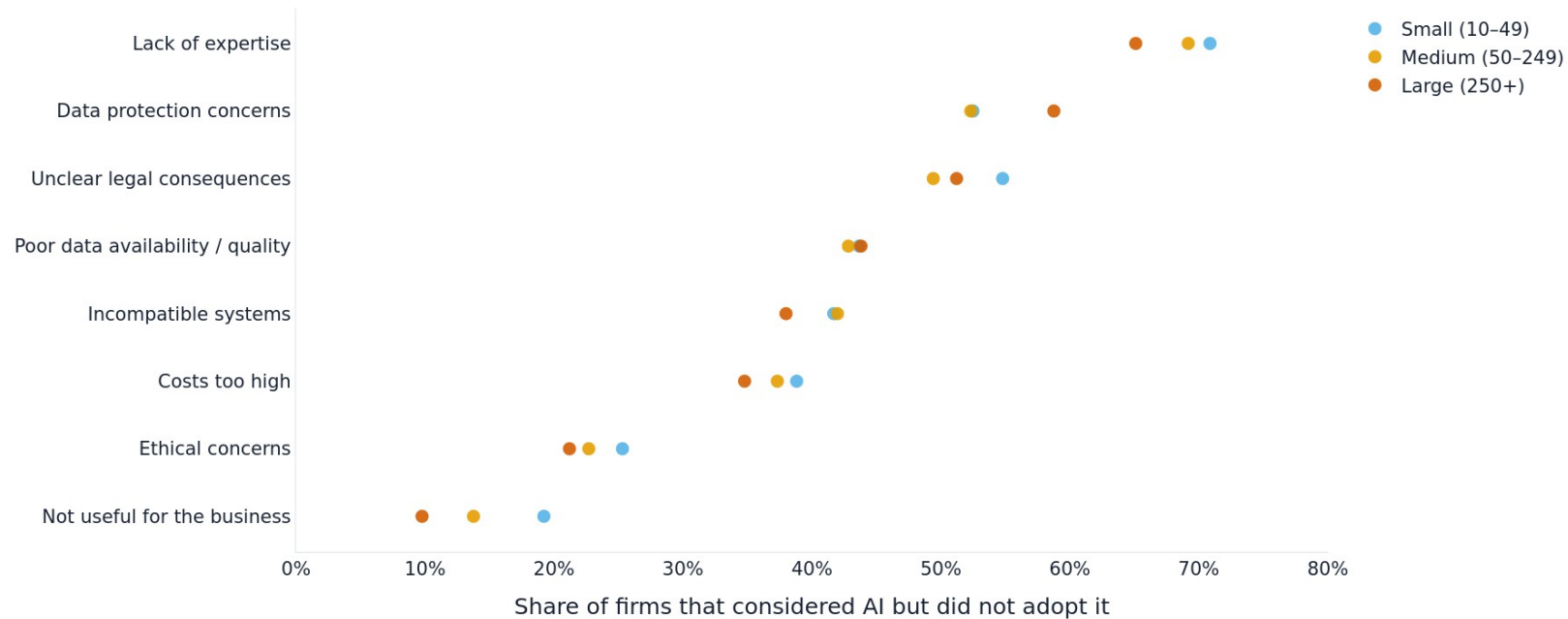
Small adopters using machine learning

The gap is about capability depth, not just initial adoption.

There is no universal AI playbook across sectors



Skills - not cost - are the dominant AI blocker



What the chart means

70.3%

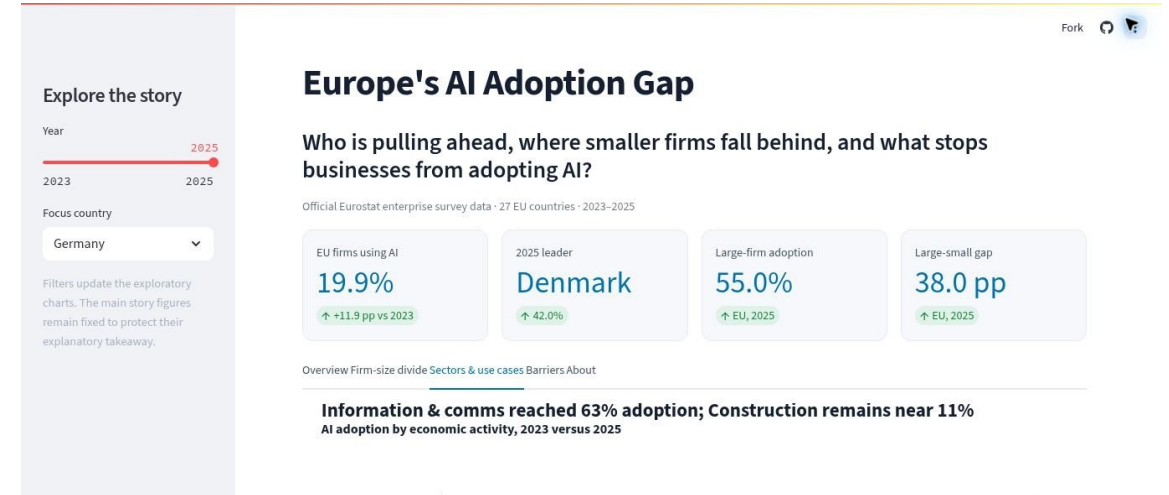
Cite a lack of expertise

#6

Cost's rank among eight barriers

Implementation capability and governance matter more than cheaper tools alone.

The dashboard turns the story into a guided exploration



Five tabs - year filter - country selector - sector and purpose explorer

GitHub: <https://github.com/Heizenberg143/eu-ai-adoption-gap>

Live dashboard: <https://usaid-eu-ai-adoption-gap.streamlit.app/>

Acceleration without convergence

Build implementation capability
Reduce governance uncertainty
Strengthen cloud and data
foundations